‘off-ramp’ would mean unacceptable concessions. They also point out any settlement is for the Ukrainians and the Russians to attempt. Whether the Cuban missile crisis is indeed the closest historical parallel to the situation in 2022, and whether building a golden bridge is the right idea, is beyond the scope of this book. Nevertheless, the idea that President Kennedy built a golden bridge over which Premier Khrushchev could retreat will be closely examined.

For Robert McNamara, ‘We can do little or nothing about human fallibility. To prevent the destruction of nations, we have no choice but to abolish nuclear weapons as swiftly and safely as possible.’[8] His conclusion was later echoed by an intriguing collection of former US officials intimately involved in nuclear weapons policies, who, in 2007, published a call for ‘A World Free of Nuclear Weapons’.[9] Mao Zedong is often credited with the observation that every Long March begins with a single step. He might have added that it helps if you are facing in the right direction and have a reliable map to hand. *The Cuban Missile Crisis: To Armageddon and Beyond* makes no attempt to provide a map for global disarmament. It makes no claims that a world free from nuclear weapons is feasible without a fundamental transformation of the global order. What it does provide is an account of the risks that humanity faced in 1962, when its survival was in peril. To examine the nature of that peril it is necessary to ask how things might have turned out differently if nuclear weapons were used. If nuclear weapons had been used in 1962, escalation to all-out thermonuclear war was not inevitable. Yet, the humanitarian costs of even a relatively small nuclear exchange in 1962 almost defies imagination. All-out thermonuclear war, and with it the end of human civilisation, almost certainly defies our imagination.

When, on 22 October 1962, the US ambassador to the United Kingdom, David Bruce, showed Harold Macmillan photographs of Soviet missiles in Cuba, the Prime Minister reflected on how Europeans had lived with the threat of Soviet nuclear weapons for many years. ‘Life goes on somehow,’ he muttered (a response that did not impress the ambassador).[10] Yet life did go on in the week from when President Kennedy announced the discovery of the missiles on Monday 22 October to when Premier Khrushchev